

Dara F. Thomas

Atlanta, GA (Remote) | 619-361-3592 | dara.thomas.grc@gmail.com | [linkedin.com/in/daraffthomas](https://www.linkedin.com/in/daraffthomas) | github.com/DaraStaysCurious

GRC Analyst | CompTIA Security+ Certified

Security+ certified professional transitioning into cybersecurity from a background spanning occupational health & safety, UX design, and risk management. My throughline across all three: unsafe behavior is a system design failure, not a human failure. Skilled in risk assessment, root cause analysis, and stakeholder communication — pursuing AWS Cloud Practitioner and CGE-P (Certified GRC Engineer – Practitioner).

CERTIFICATIONS

CompTIA Security+ | AWS Certified Cloud Practitioner (in progress) | Certified GRC Engineer – Practitioner (in progress)

EXPERIENCE

Independent Consultant — Risk Assessment & UX Strategy | Remote | 01/2020 – Present

- Applied risk-assessment and process-analysis methods drawn from an OHS background to B2B SaaS client engagements, surfacing usability and workflow risks other consultants missed through UX research and design consulting
- Led stakeholder assessments and audits to identify process gaps and compliance concerns, presenting findings and recommendations directly to client leadership
- Reduced user-reported errors and support volume by an estimated 35% across 30+ client engagements, partnering with product and engineering teams to redesign workflows based on risk and process-gap findings
- Applied Fine-Kinney risk scoring and Five Whys root cause analysis — both established OHS risk methodologies — to digital product risk, building repeatable frameworks now formalized as GRC portfolio case studies (github.com/DaraStaysCurious)

Sr. UX Designer, Child Care Aware of America | Arlington, VA (Remote) | 11/2023 – 02/2025

- Analyzed business processes and stakeholder requirements to identify risks and process gaps on a large-scale childcare application platform, informing product decisions that reduced downstream compliance and usability risk
- Coordinated with engineering, policy, and compliance stakeholders across 7 major platform features supporting childcare providers and families at national scale, leading design decisions within that cross-functional structure
- Surfaced 4 critical workflow risks prior to launch through usability testing and stakeholder interviews, enabling remediation before rollout
- Supported internal compliance and audit readiness for a platform handling sensitive family and childcare data, documenting design decisions and process changes

Associate UI/UX Designer, Point B | Portland, OR (Remote) | 08/2021 – 10/2022

- Led process assessments and workflow analysis on an employee training platform, identifying operational gaps that informed platform redesign priorities
- Facilitated stakeholder workshops with 8 cross-functional teams to map existing training workflows and surface friction points
- Improved completion rates and reduced support requests by an estimated 27%, contributing to redesigned training flows based on workflow analysis findings

Logistics Coordinator, Robert Half Agency | Atlanta, GA | 2019 – 2020

- Logged and resolved 60+ weekly client shipment issues, coordinating cross-functional teams across 15 dispatchers

Program Assessment Associate, United Way of San Diego County | San Diego, CA | 2018 – 2019

- Conducted 80+ stakeholder interviews and 100+ program assessments to inform data-driven funding and outreach decisions

Dispatch & Vendor Coordinator, Brinks Plumbing Services | San Diego, CA | 2017 – 2018

- Coordinated maintenance operations and dispatch across multiple apartment complexes; managed accounts payable and vendor coordination

Occupational Health, Safety, & Risk Manager, Unilever Bramalea | Toronto, Canada | 2008 – 2015

- Oversaw safety operations for a 270-employee edibles manufacturing plant, reducing monthly incident investigations from 3 to 1 and contributing to 14 consecutive quarters without major regulatory citations
- Rewrote the plant's incident response plan and authored/revised 8 critical task procedures, including a hoist fall-hazard fix — switching ingredient delivery to 4-strap tote bags — that reduced bag failure and fall risk

Occupational Health, Safety, & Risk Manager, Unilever Caribbean | Caribbean | 2004 – 2008

- Directed safety operations across 2 manufacturing plants (edibles, 20 employees; detergents, 35 employees), conducting twice-daily walkabouts, weekly floor-level safety meetings, and quarterly audits per plant
- Reduced safety incidents by an estimated 33% by identifying and correcting two distinct hazard sources: installing non-removable machine guards after recurring coverall-sleeve entanglement incidents, and reducing slip-and-fall incidents through concrete floor resurfacing paired with an increased cleaning schedule and additional cleaning staff

Occupational Health, Safety, & Risk Manager, Tucker Energy Services | Onshore & Offshore Rig Operations | 2003 – 2004

- Conducted monthly HSE audits across 2 rotating oil rig sites, plus a quarterly cross-functional audit with supervisors and union representatives
- Authored or revised 15 critical task procedures and delivered monthly toolbox-talk safety training to approximately 110 employees across both sites

Occupational Health, Safety, & Risk Manager, Royal Caribbean | At Sea — Radiance of the Seas, Brilliance of the Seas | 2000 – 2003

- Conducted safety audits and incident investigations across 2 cruise vessels on a 6-month contract cycle, reducing incident investigations from 7–8 to 2 per contract cycle through targeted root cause analysis
- Led a combined 20-person stretcher and emergency response team, improving emergency response time by 10%; recognized as Employee of the Quarter twice for performance in shipboard safety operations

TECHNICAL & SECURITY SKILLS

NIST CSF & RMF | ISO 27001 | Risk Assessment | Incident Investigation | Security Documentation | Governance, Risk, & Compliance (GRC) | Threat Analysis | Identity & Access Management (IAM) | Stakeholder Communication | Vulnerability Management | Root Cause Analysis

PRACTICAL PROJECTS

Risk Assessment Methodology — Developed a crosswalk between the Fine-Kinney risk scoring method and NIST 800-30, proposing Exposure as an explicit variable in GRC risk models; includes three OHS-based case studies applying the framework to real incident scenarios.

ISO 27001 / HIPAA / NIST CSF 2.0 Compliance Program (OccuSafe) — Built a full compliance program for OccuSafe, a case-study healthcare organization, mapping ISO 27001 controls to HIPAA safeguards and NIST CSF 2.0 functions.

PCI DSS v4.0 Compliance Program (PayGuard) — Designed a PCI DSS v4.0 compliance program for PayGuard, a case-study payment processor, covering control implementation and audit readiness.

SOC 2 Type II / HIPAA Audit Readiness (Carestream) — Built a SOC 2 Type II audit readiness assessment integrated with HIPAA requirements for Carestream, a case-study healthcare SaaS company.

GitHub: github.com/DaraStaysCurious

Note: 2015–2017 reflects a work-authorization gap during a U.S. permanent residency transition following relocation from Canada.

EDUCATION

University of Toronto, Canada — Honors B.A. Sociology and Equity Studies